# The Effects of Initial Placement

## Evidence from Economics Job Market Flyouts

**León Tagle** Caleb Brobst

September 17, 2026

# Introduction

- **This paper:** the effect of a good initial placement after the PhD on economists' medium-run publication output.
- **Main tasks:**
  1. Isolate the effect of placement net of selection.
  2. Identify mechanisms through a rich dataset.
- **Main strategy:** narrow list of final candidates; compare **winners vs. losers** (Greenstone, Hornbeck & Moretti, 2010; Kline & Moretti, 2013; Borjas & Doran, 2015).
- **Future alternative:** within-field variation over time in **job opportunities by cohort**, as in the literature on graduating in a recession (e.g. Oreopoulos, von Wachter & Heisz, 2012).

# Motivation and related literature

1. **Labor:** effect of initial placement on long-term outcomes (Oyer, 2006; Arellano-Bover, 2024).
   - \+ Well micro-founded comparison group; individual productivity measures.
   - − External validity of a niche setting.
2. **Science of science:** inputs of scientific production (Azoulay et al., 2010; Way et al., 2024).
   - Another type of quasi-experimental setting.
3. **Economics of economics** (Angrist et al., 2020; 2024; 2026).

**Extrinsic motivation:**

- A framework for agentic collection and processing of mostly structured data.
- Pretty funny.

# Data: EJMR job market tracker

- Studied before: Ederer, Goldsmith-Pinkham & Jensen (2024), *Anonymity and Identity Online*... but Bryan (2019) *did* use it as a job market source, initially.
- Threads track **flyouts**, often with now-deprecated conference links.
- Also whether an **offer** was extended and/or accepted ("R" for *rumors*).
- Acceptance: our initial information, validated against **employment histories**.

Versions:

7880 - 09/02 00:31:55 (Current)
7879 - 09/02 00:28:49
7878 - 09/02 00:28:36
7877 - 09/02 00:28:21
7876 - 09/02 00:28:05
7875 - 09/02 00:28:00
7874 - 09/02 00:27:52
7873 - 09/02 00:27:34
7872 - 09/02 00:27:18
7871 - 09/02 00:27:09
7870 - 09/02 00:26:58

| School | Field | Deadline | Description | ASSA/AEA | Earliest call | Most recent call | Rejection | Campus Invitations | Earliest Invitatio | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Bocconi University | Any | 12/02/15 | Description Apply | Yes | 12/15/2015 | 12/15/2015 | | Gorlach (UCL); Porzio (Yale); Wuetrich (Bern); Heise (Yale); Galle (Berkeley); Bellon (Columbia); Smolin (Yale); Santangelo (Yale); Muller (Berkeley); http://goo.gl/FeUtFa | | | | |
| Boston College | Any | 11/30/15 | Description Apply | | 12/08/15 | 12/09/15 | | Illanes (MIT), Ganong (Harvard), http://goo.gl/LQUn6z | | | | 01/15/16 |
| Boston U | Assistant Professor - Economics | | | Yes | 12/04/2015 | 12/08/2015 | | Doval (Northwestern), Liang (Harvard), Lipnowski (NYU),Denti (MIT),Wüthrich(Bern), Liao (Maryland), Hanlon (UCLA), Ganong (Harvard), Pandalai-Nayar (Michigan), Perez-Truglia (Microsoft) Restrepo(MIT) Porzio (Yale) | Doval (Northwestern), Lipnowski (NYU Stern), Restrepo (MIT), Feigenbaum (Harvard) | Restrepo (MIT), Feigenbaum (Harvard) | 03/31/16 | |

# The pipeline: From scraped data to candidate panels

1. **Set up candidate ground truths**
   - EJMR flyouts (market year, affiliation, placement).
   - Placement lists (quality and coverage vary).
   - Faculty rosters (2010–2025, scraped from Wayback snapshots).
2. **Find online profiles** ▸ Website ledger
   - Story pieced together from the ground truths; manual check if uncertain.
   - Mainly CV and personal websites; also other websites.
3. **Parse the CV** (and later, the website)
   - Publications, education, professional positions, awards and grants, etc.
4. **Complement EJMR position choice sets** with résumé information; determine the final placement of candidates.
5. **Journal weights** à la Angrist, from OpenAlex. ▸ Weights
6. *In the future:* match individual publications to OpenAlex, and dissertations to ProQuest.

# Summary stats on current sample

2013–2016: 301 unique candidates in 75 top-8 positions (job postings)
44 are viable (80 accepted, 93 controls)

Dropped candidates include 24 non-ladder placements, 16 already employed, 31 that lacked within position treatment/control, etc.

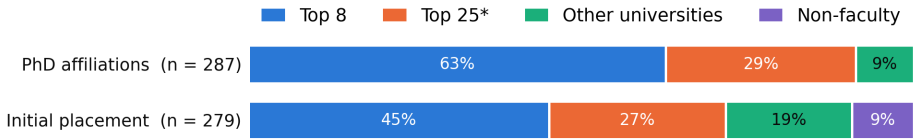



Excludes already employed candidates. **Top 8:** MIT, Harvard, Stanford, Berkeley, Yale, Princeton, Chicago, Northwestern. Includes their business schools + HKS. **Top 25*:** Other universities in the top 26 for Economics in the USNews ranking, + 3 other elite european universities.

# Summary stats on current sample

2013–2016: 301 unique candidates in 75 top-8 positions (job postings)
44 are viable (80 accepted, 93 controls)

Dropped candidates include 24 non-ladder placements, 16 already employed, 31 that lacked within position treatment/control, etc.

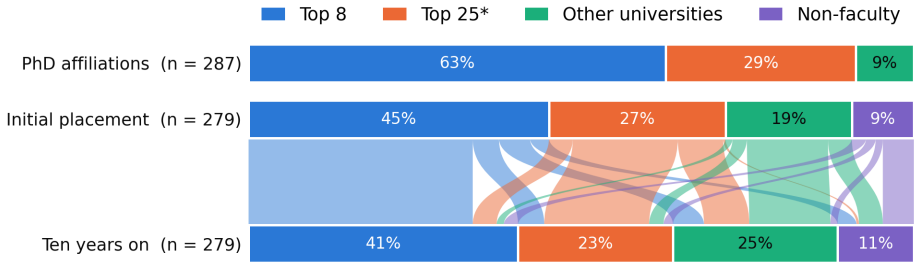



Excludes already employed candidates. **Top 8:** MIT, Harvard, Stanford, Berkeley, Yale, Princeton, Chicago, Northwestern. Includes their business schools + HKS. **Top 25*:** Other universities in the top 26 for Economics in the USNews ranking, + 3 other elite european universities. **Placement** accounts for interim post-doc of up to 3 years before starting faculty position, if there is one.

# Summary stats on current sample

2013–2016: 301 unique candidates in 75 top-8 positions (job postings)
44 are viable (80 accepted, 93 controls)

Dropped candidates include 24 non-ladder placements, 16 already employed, 31 that lacked within position treatment/control, etc.

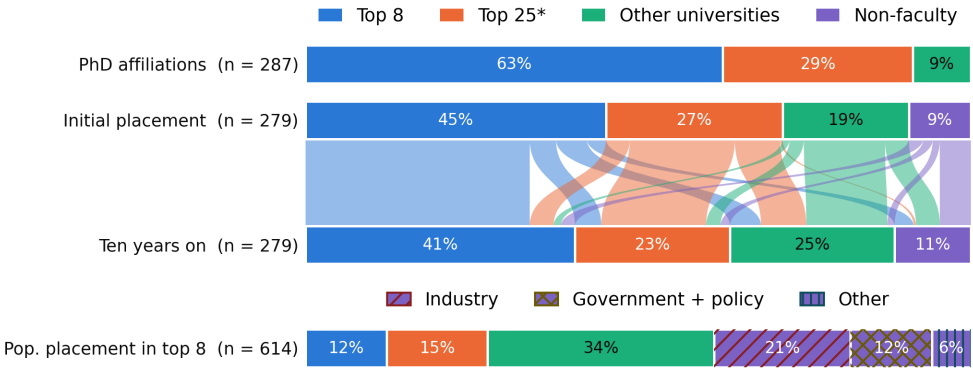



Excludes already employed candidates. **Top 8:** MIT, Harvard, Stanford, Berkeley, Yale, Princeton, Chicago, Northwestern. Includes their business schools + HKS. **Top 25*:** Other universities in the top 26 for Economics in the USNews ranking, + 3 other elite european universities. **Placement** accounts for interim post-doc of up to 3 years before starting faculty position, if there is one.

# Summary stats on current sample

2013–2016: 301 unique candidates in 75 top-8 positions (job postings)
44 are viable (80 accepted, 93 controls)

Dropped candidates include 24 non-ladder placements, 16 already employed, 31 that lacked within position treatment/control, etc.



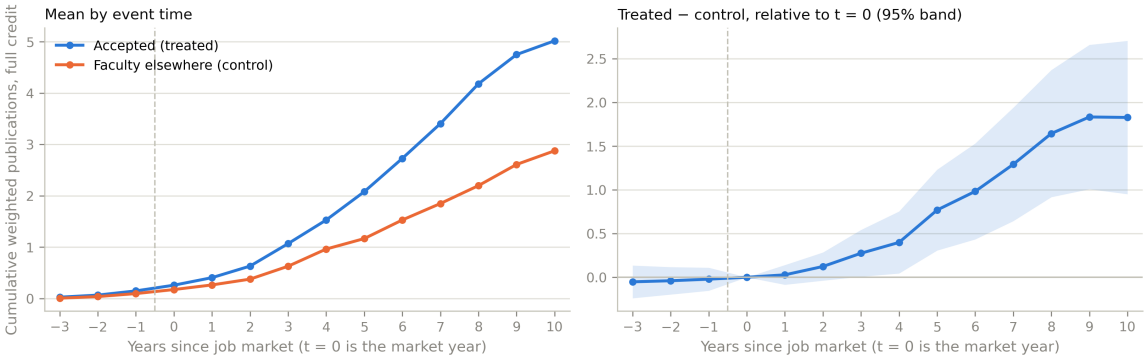

Excludes already employed candidates. **Top 8:** MIT, Harvard, Stanford, Berkeley, Yale, Princeton, Chicago, Northwestern. Includes their business schools + HKS. **Top 25*:** Other universities in the top 26 for Economics in the USNews ranking, + 3 other elite european universities. **Placement** accounts for interim post-doc of up to 3 years before starting faculty position, if there is one.

**Pop. placement:** *Doesn't* account for post-doc if reported as placement. Every graduate the eight departments' own pages list for 2013–2016 — Berkeley 121 (with Haas), Harvard 109 (with HKS), Northwestern 84 (with Kellogg), Yale 82 (with SOM), Princeton 79, Stanford 79, Chicago 35, MIT 26 (2016 alone).

# Initial result: the naïve event study

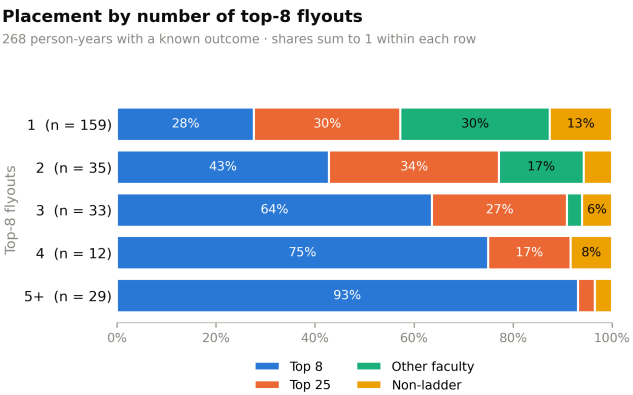
**Within position — cumulative weighted publications, full credit**

44 positions · 80 treated · 93 control persons · 203 candidate rows




All candidates. Outcome: cumulative Deep Impact-weighted publications, full credit to every coauthor (as opposed to $1/n$ as Angrist does). Treated: accepted the top-8 position; control: flew out to the same position and placed as faculty outside the top 8. Position × event-time fixed effects, SEs clustered by person.

# The problem: lack of overlap






**José Ignacio Cuesta**

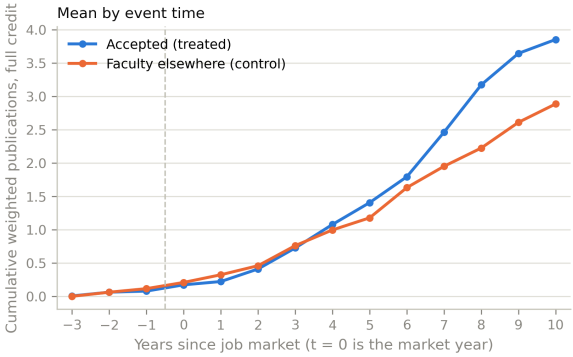
Chicago, 2019 market

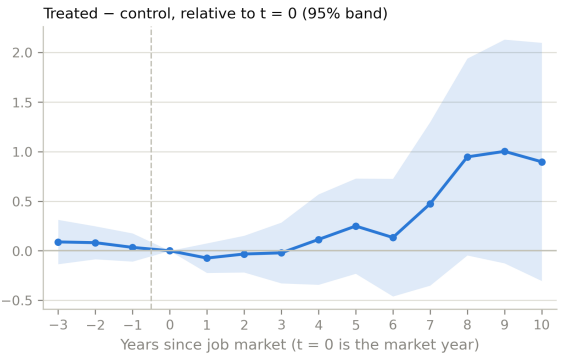
- 11 flyouts, incl. MIT, Princeton, Northwestern, Stanford, Booth.
- Yale apparently made an offer.

# More restricted result

**Within position, candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts — cumulative weighted publications, full credit**

24 positions · 33 treated · 54 control persons · 93 candidate rows




Candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts; otherwise as in the first result. Position × event-time fixed effects, SEs clustered by person.

▸ Partial credit (1/n) ▸ Pooled, full credit ▸ Top 5 only ▸ Ex-ante controls

# Conclusion

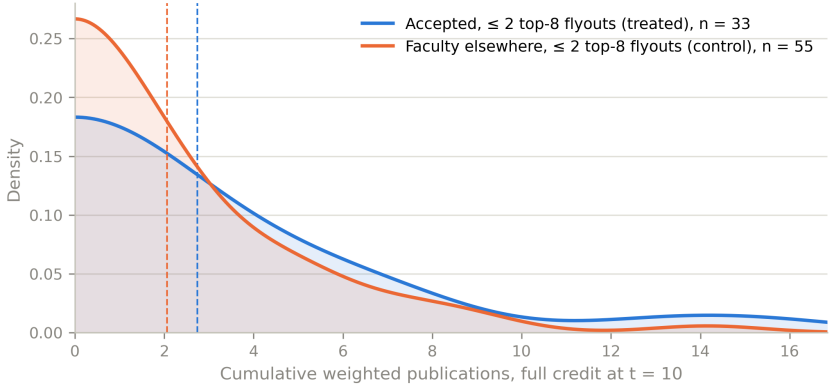
- **Visible effects** but wanting for power, at the moment.
- **Incoming sources of power**:
  1. Closer look at current set-up post-parsing (a bit rushed for this).
  2. We'll be parsing **personal websites** too, and entering manually from other website as last recourse.
  3. Could **extend the sample** from 2016 to 2018.
  4. *In the future*: Do an equivalent comparison of **top 25 vs. anything else** (many more events).
- **Overall steps for this project**:
  1. Posting candidates event study, trying out **increasingly stringent** specifications (*in progress*).
  2. **Alternative design** exploiting temporal shifts in field-specific postings (Caleb comes in).
  3. Combining all of our data in search of **mechanisms** (as much as we can from CVs, faculty rosters for networks, field info, etc.).

Thank you :)

# Distribution of outcomes by year 10

**Pooled, candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts — distribution at t = 10**

Cumulative weighted publications, full credit · dashed lines mark the group medians



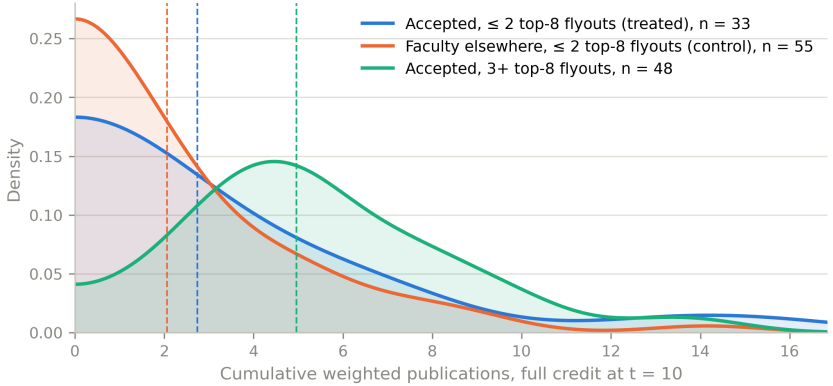

Pooled $\leq$ 2-flyout sample, one row per person and market year: cumulative Deep Impact-weighted publications ten years after the market, full credit to every coauthor. Gaussian kernel density reflected at zero; the dashed lines mark the group medians.

Already-employed candidates are out of every group.

# Distribution of outcomes by year 10

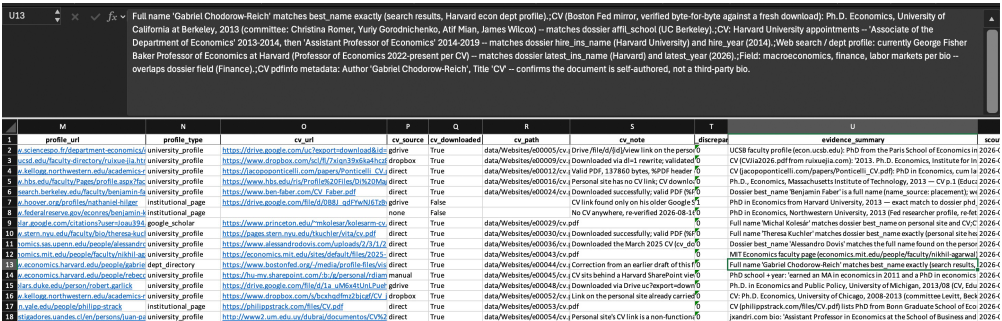
**Pooled, candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts — distribution at t = 10**

Cumulative weighted publications, full credit · dashed lines mark the group medians




Pooled ≤ 2-flyout sample, one row per person and market year: cumulative Deep Impact-weighted publications ten years after the market, full credit to every coauthor. Gaussian kernel density reflected at zero; the dashed lines mark the group medians. The second step adds every accepted candidate with 3 or more top-8 flyouts, over all their markets rather than only the positions the event studies use. Already-employed candidates are out of every group.

# Website ledger




One row per candidate, 314 in all: the site the scout found, checked against the ground truth. 297 personal sites, 15 profile pages only, 2 not found; 295 CVs on disk.

◂ Back

# Journal weights: top 15

| Journal | 2021 | 2015 | Angrist 2015 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Quarterly Journal of Economics | 1.72 | 1.34 | |
| Econometrica | 1.05 | 1.33 | |
| American Economic Review | 1.01 | 0.91 | |
| Journal of Political Economy | 0.78 | 0.69 | |
| Review of Economic Studies | 0.60 | 0.74 | |
| AEJ: Macroeconomics | 0.42 | 0.49 | |
| AEJ: Applied Economics | 0.40 | 0.48 | 0.44 |
| AEJ: Economic Policy | 0.31 | 0.31 | 0.24 |
| Journal of Economic Perspectives | 0.30 | 0.21 | 0.30 |
| AER: Insights | 0.29 | — | |
| Quantitative Economics | 0.27 | 0.38 | |
| Journal of Labor Economics | 0.27 | 0.17 | |
| Journal of the European Econ. Assoc. | 0.25 | 0.24 | |
| Review of Economics and Statistics | 0.22 | 0.20 | |
| Journal of Finance | 0.21 | 0.16 | |

Weights in **top-five article equivalents**: the average article in AER, Econometrica, JPE, QJE or REStud is worth one (Angrist, Diederichs & Ellison, 2026), recomputed from OpenAlex.

**How:** cites from recent top-five articles to a journal's prior five years, per article published.

**2021**: cites from 2017–2021 articles (used).
**2015**: from 2011–2015, comparable to the paper, which prints three of these weights.

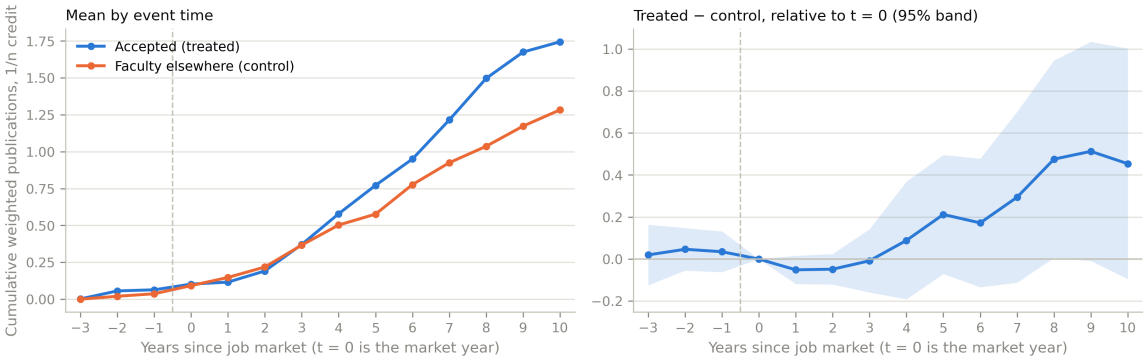
AER: Insights has no articles before 2019.

Back

# Final result: partial credit (1/n)

**Within position, candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts — cumulative weighted publications, 1/n credit**

24 positions · 33 treated · 54 control persons · 93 candidate rows



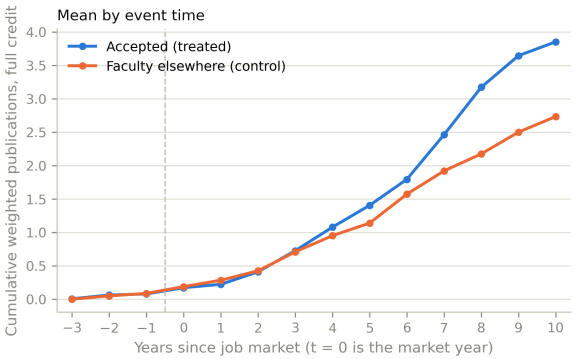

As in the restricted result, but each paper's weight is split $1/n$ across its authors, the convention in Angrist, Diederichs & Ellison. Candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts; position × event-time fixed effects, SEs clustered by person.

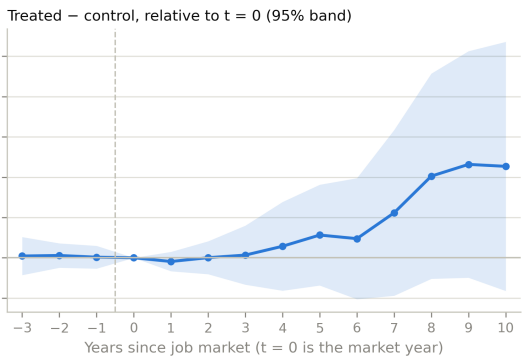
Back

# Final result: pooled, full credit

**Pooled, candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts — cumulative weighted publications, full credit**

33 treated · 54 control persons · 88 person-markets



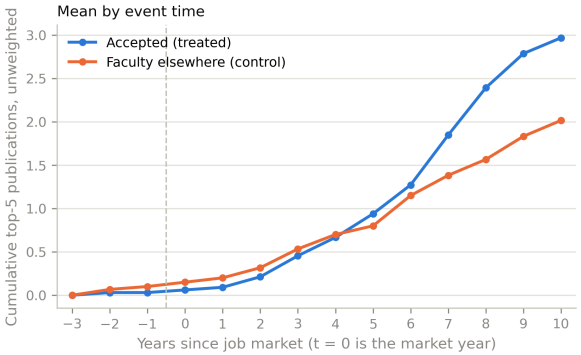

As in the restricted result, but pooled: event-time fixed effects only, with no position × event-time term, and one row per candidate and market rather than one per position they flew to. Full credit to every coauthor, SEs clustered by person.

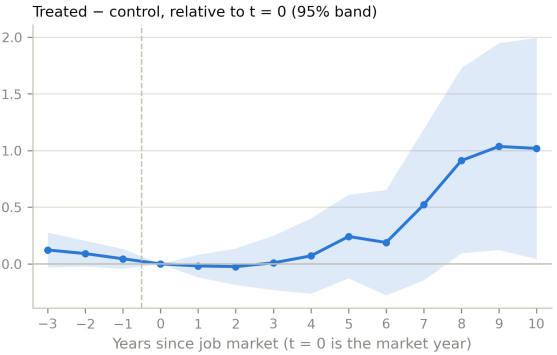
Back

# Final result: top 5 only

**Within position, candidates with at most 2 top-8 flyouts — cumulative top-5 publications, unweighted**

24 positions · 33 treated · 54 control persons · 93 candidate rows



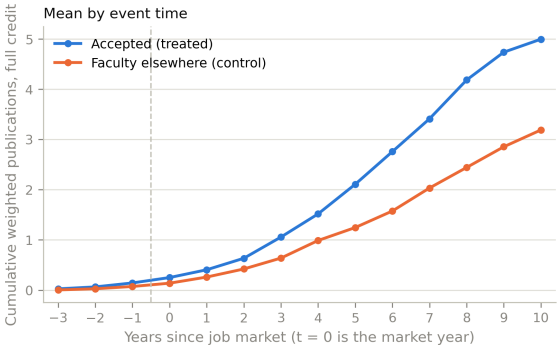

As in the restricted result, but the outcome counts top-five publications, unweighted, instead of the Deep Impact-weighted total. Position × event-time fixed effects, SEs clustered by person.

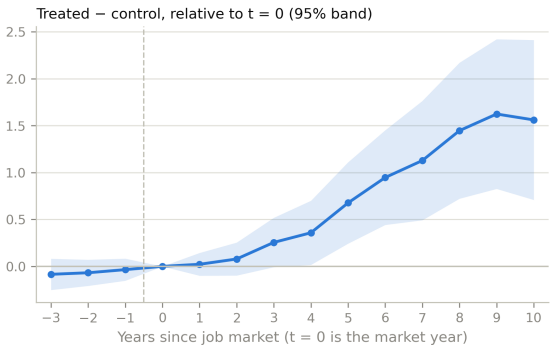
◂ Back

# Final result: ex-ante controls, full credit

**Within position, ex-ante controls (faculty anywhere, top 8 included) — cumulative weighted publications, full credit**

47 positions · 83 treated · 118 control persons · 248 candidate rows




Every usable position, with no cap on top-8 flyouts, and the control group defined *ex ante*: anyone who flew to the position and landed a faculty job anywhere, the top 8 included. A candidate who accepted a top-8 position elsewhere in the same market is never a control. Full credit to every coauthor; position × event-time fixed effects, SEs clustered by person.

Back